System 105 (2022) 102751

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

System

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/system

Exploring the use of collaborative autoethnography as a tool for facilitating the development of researcher reflexivity

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
Collaborative autoethnography
Researcher reflexivity
Researcher professional development
Self-reflective data

ABSTRACT

This study explored the experiences of two practitioner researchers engaged in qualitative research at a Japanese university, by employing the collaborative autoethnographic-oriented approach (CAE). Drawing on data from a previous longitudinal research on learner autonomy, the methodological aspect of the research was reflected upon by focusing on the interview process, in an attempt to explore how CAE could function as a tool for further professional development. Drawing upon the iterative nature of the reflexivity (Chang et al., 2013; Finlay, 2012; Mann & Walsh, 2017), the data collection process involved cycles of individual meta-reflections on the diaries maintained in the previous study, and audio recorded face-to-face discussions of the pre and post-dialogue reflective writings of the researchers. The dialogic accounts strengthened the researchers' understanding of how they were connected to the research context both on micro and macro levels, and how these two dimensions intertwined to provide new meanings to their sense of self, experiences, and knowledge building. On the basis of the discussion it was concluded that CAE performs dual functions: it is not only a research methodology but can also serve as an effective tool for promoting professional development of researchers through reflexivity.

1. Introduction

This study is a series of a government funded research conducted between 2012 and 2016 on fostering learner autonomy in the context of a university-wide English program in Japan (Miyahara et al., 2016). Semi-structured interviews (Kvale & Brinkmann, 2009) are one of the main data collection methods employed by a team of researchers, including the two authors of this article. For the purpose of information sharing among the group of researchers, individual researchers maintained a research diary from 2012 to 2016 containing information regarding the use of this method. In the current study, we shift the focus onto ourselves to reflect on our experiences and explore them as practitioners and researchers by using the research diaries as the starting point. The data for the study was generated in the form of reflective writing and recorded conversations over a period of nine months. In pursuance of the aims of the present research, we adopted a collaborative autoethnographic (CAE) approach, as we believed that our collaborative dialogues would allow us to build up on our individual experiences, provide insights, and deepen our understanding regarding the use of interviews as a data collection method in research.

In line with Chang et al.'s (2013) study, we understand that CAE is a transformative process whereby 'researchers create community, advance scholarship, and become empowered within [their] social context' (ibid. p. 36). The main source of our research data was a series of face-to-face collaborative dialogues, pre and post-dialogue reflective writings. The aim was to explore how and to what

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https://doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2022.102751
Received 13 May 2021; Received in revised form 11 January 2022; Accepted 13 January 2022
Available online 20 January 2022
0346-251X/© 2022 Published by Elsevier Ltd.

extent the CAE approach contributes (or does not) to researcher's reflexivity in the process of collecting, analysing, and representing the interview data. We argue that CAE functions not only as a research methodology and method, but also as a creative tool for professional development that helps to facilitate and enhance researcher's reflexivity. There are different types of collaborative autoethnographic approaches such as duoethnography, autoethnographic conversations, community autoethnography, and performance collaborative autoethnography (Chang et al., 2013). We opted for a broad CAE approach because we wanted to focus on the collaborative and reflective nature of the researchers rather than the group size or the extent of collaboration.

In this article, we firstly provide a brief review of CAE as a research approach and outline its benefits. We then present a discussion on CAE as a means to enhance researcher reflexivity by analysing excerpts from our journals and dialogues. We conclude by suggesting not only the potential benefits, but also the limitations in implementing such an approach in our professional lives.

2. Literature review: situating the scene

2.1. What is collaborative autoethnography (CAE)?

In general, autoethnography (AE) has long been understood as a means of qualitative inquiry where the individual researcher presents an account of their personal experience, and analyses it in terms of its cultural context and implications (Bruner, 1986; Denzin, 2003; Jones et al., 2013). CAE shares these fundamental insights, but emphasis is placed both on the process of meaning-making by a group as well as by individuals (Denzin, 2013). According to Chang et al. (2013), CAE is 'a qualitative research method in which researchers work in community to collect their autobiographical materials and to analyse and interpret their data collectively to gain a meaningful understanding of sociocultural phenomena reflected in their autobiographical data' (p. 24). Lapadat (2017), in line with the ideas of Chang et al. (2013), also conceptualises CAE as a multi vocal approach to ethnography 'in which a team of two or more researchers work together to share personal stories and interpret the pooled autoethnographic data, extends the reach of AE and offers ways to address some of its methodological and ethical issues' (Chang et al., 2013, p. 590). Etherington (2007) also favours the adoption of reflexive research methods that are pursued in a collaborative manner. Furthermore, other studies that have utilised CAE include Austin et al.'s work (2017) that explored the development of identities as female leaders. Another example is Wong and Tiu-Wu's study (2014) on the complexity of multicultural experience of Asian immigrant academics in the West. Thus, the cooperative element of collaborative work in CAE allows researchers to be self-focused in a certain social context, in an interactively and critically dialogic manner. The key feature of this multidimensional perspective is the ability to alternate between group and individual work at all stages of the research and engage in an iterative individual and group meaning-making processes. We found this methodological orientation to be most effective in pursuing our research inquiries because of its collaborative focus as well as its iterative nature which appears to be more conducive to exploring the methodological and ethical dilemmas pertaining to researcher's reflexivity.

2.2. CAE and researcher reflexivity

The notion of researcher reflexivity is of central concern as more and more researchers have begun to recognise the intricate and complex relationship between the researcher's subjectivity and their research process and product. Moreover, the researchers generally admit that in any research, they are an inevitable part of the study. This may be said to be applicable to AE as well since the researchers utilise their experiences and participate in the research in such a way that they perform both the roles (i.e., that of the subject and the researcher) (Coffey, 2002). How researchers consider the effect of their presence on their research is a critical issue, and many academics like Schwandt (2014) have incorporated the notion of 'reflexivity' to address their concerns.

Discussions on incorporating researcher reflexivity, as an important strategy in the research process have received increased recognition (Berger, 2015; Finlay, 2012; Mann & Walsh, 2017; Miyahara, 2015, 2019; Prior, 2016; Riessman, 2012). However, factors such as the effects researcher reflexivity could have on the research outcomes, researchers' positionality in terms of the participants, or how they are situated in their specific research context have not been fully exploited. Additionally, there is a lack of consensus regarding the concept of reflexivity, which is often confused with reflection. Drawing from Finlay's (2012) study, we infer that reflection means 'thinking about' something after the event, and reflexivity refers to 'engaging in an ongoing self-awareness,' which means that the former is a more descriptive process as compared to the latter which concerns ways in which a researcher positions themselves in the research context and contemplates how their own self could influence their actions.

Generally, reflexivity consists of two broad dimensions: self-understanding of researchers' own positionality and how that understanding affects the overall research process and outcomes. However, the emphasis is not to be laid on the importance of reflexivity but on the ways or means of its attainement and its effects on the research outcomes and on the researcher's position. Furthermore, from a broader perspective, Schwandt (2014) argues that self-reflexivity does not merely pertain to the 'self.' Lapadat (2017) explains that reflexive researchers 'situate themselves in the study by revealing their background and personal perspectives, theoretical stance, style of interactions, political aims, and understanding acquired through the research' (p. 591). Additionally, another important aspect is the temporal element to reflexivity, since it is easier to notice the 'blind spots' after some time has passed, for stronger reflexivity (Finlay, 2012). This point is particularly relevant to our present study as we recollect our reflections of our previous research study, and, for this very reason, many scholars have described reflexivity in terms of its cyclical nature (Edge, 2011). Although some scholars like Guillemin and Gillam (2004) have criticised reflexivity because of its potentially self-indulgent nature, Doyle (2013) posits that researchers' background, their personal perspectives, their theoretical stance, as well as their style of interactions 'must be thought about and analyzed, and the analysis used purposefully in the research process' (p. 253). The reason behind this is that, for the researchers, an important point of consideration is to be able to always consider and explore how the disclosure of their positionality and

their views towards the construction of knowledge contribute to their understanding of the phenomena at hand. CAE takes the understanding of the concept of reflexivity to a higher level by incorporating the process of self-reflexivity in collaboration with other researchers. Reflexive researchers acknowledge the slippery process of the researcher's reflexivity (Davies et al., 2006), which leads to merely biased interpretations. They are aware that their own objectivity is a fiction, and fully recognise that their accounts could merely be the consequences of their observations and their viewpoints, that were derived at a certain time and place. The collaborative nature of CAE contributes towards the minimisation of such shortcomings through dialogues among the researchers, so as to counter-balance the researchers' subjectivity.

Chang et al. (2013) asserts that there are five interrelated methodological benefits for using a CAE approach: 1) collective exploration of researcher subjectivity; 2) power-sharing among research participants; 3) efficiency and enrichment of the research process; 4) deeper learning about self and others; and 5) community building (p. 25). The themes that emerged from the data generated in the current study highlight the first and the fourth benefits most prominently, and show rather indirect connections to the others. Hence, our analysis will focus on the issues related to these two benefits.

3. Methods

3.1. Our previous study on learner autonomy (2012–2016)

In order to pursue the main aim of our present study, we reflected back on our previous research that explored ways of fostering and developing learner autonomy in the context of a university curriculum, classroom-based practices, and materials. It was a government funded research (MEXT Grant-in-Aid #2452068) (Miyahara et al., 2016) that involved five researchers, including the investigators of the present study, who worked in a program along with teachers; each member had their unique expertise and background. The research project was a longitudinal study and the data for the study were gathered between 2012 and 2016. There were two groups of participants: one group comprised first-year students and the other consisted mainly of second-year students. All participants were recruited on a voluntary basis. Data for the study was collected in the form of students' reflective tasks, responses to interviews, journals, and portfolios of students' work. Specific students were assigned to each researcher, who conducted as many as fourteen student interviews within a time span of two years. The five researchers also maintained a research diary along with the data collected from the participants, throughout the research process. Their diaries were basically free-flowing, but they were asked to make the entries after each interview in order to facilitate their reflection on the interviews. The data for our current research is generated from these diaries, made during the study on learner autonomy almost five years ago.

3.2. Participants and their profiles

Researcher A was the chief researcher of the learner autonomy research (2012–2016) who designed the study and led the group of teachers. During the learner autonomy research, she organized numerous study sessions on research methodology and methods by focusing on interviews as a data collection method. It was during a previous research project (2012–2016) that she became more interested in the methodological aspects of qualitative research.

Researcher B, another researcher involved in the learner autonomy research, was less experienced as a researcher, but had a longer teaching experience. She undertook online courses on research methods, and conducted studies involving interviews. Both researchers found that they shared a common interest in the methodological aspects of the study, and were engaged in occasional conversations outside the study sessions.

Looking back, we realise that through the research project, we developed a new relationship as co-researchers in addition to the relationship as colleagues. The common interest in research methodology as well as in reflecting on the previous research, which we, as researchers shared, motivated us to undertake the current study. The fact that we were on sabbatical at the same time in 2018 allowed us to pursue this study as we could devote a significant amount of time and in-depth contemplation in research.

3.3. Data collection and analysis

Data for the current study were collected over nine months which was a cyclical process involving: individual reflective writing, collaborative face-to-face dialogues, and post-dialogue reflective writing. The cycle of preliminary and subsequent data collection as described in Chang et al. (2013, p. 24) was slightly modified to pursue the research objectives. First, we reviewed our research diaries, which we maintained during the learner autonomy research between 2012 and 2016. As we read and reflected upon our thoughts which we had penned down that time, we noted down our personal reflections regarding them. A total of eight entries in the research diaries were revisited, and we decided to focus on one or two entries at a time for reflection and discussion. Face-to-face dialogues started with sharing individual pre-dialogue written reflections and questions with the partner researcher. This was followed by a series of free-flowing face-to-face dialogues about the themes that emerged from our conversations that would last for about 60–90 min. The audio recording of the dialogues were used as a resource by both of us for listening before our post-dialogue reflective writing began. This cycle was repeated until all eight entries of the research diaries were revisited. It could be said that the primary data were the reflection of one's own experience, and the subsequent data were the collaborative reflection on one's own experience as well as the partner researcher's experience through dialogues, including post-dialogue reflective writing (see Fig. 1). This somewhat lengthy process enabled 'collective exploration of researcher subjectivity' (Chang et al., 2013, p. 25) to attain 'deeper learning about self and other' (ibid. p. 2).

The data analyses involved individual as well as collaborative work. All the data created were digitised and were readily available to both of us. Each investigator went through the data separately, primarily the individual pre and post-dialogue reflective writing and the recorded dialogues, for the purpose of coding, to identify salient themes of the research questions. As Riessman (2008) and many others (e.g. Block, 2009) have advocated, the first step is to conduct a series of thematic data analysis (*what*) and the second step is to examine how these themes, in terms of the dialogue or conversation, are organized *(how*). Finally, the third step is to focus on how these dialogues are 'co-produced (*what and how*) in a complex choreography-in spaces between the teller and listener, speaker and setting, text and reader, history and culture' (Riessman, 2008, p. 105). In other words, what is said should be examined with respect to how participants regard themselves, and are regarded in the course of interaction, which should then be considered at a broader level encompassing larger social constructs, such as identities or social groups (Miyahara, 2015).

Subsequently, a comparison between pre and post-dialogue reflective writing was done extensively in order to investigate the effects of our collaborative dialogues (Fig. 2). The first column, STEP 1, involved the process of individual reflections which were noted at the time the original data were collected. STEP 2 involved reflection on our discussions from our original research diaries in STEP 1. Finally, both researchers contemplated the conversations in STEP 2, and made their final entries in the third column, STEP 3. The individual analysis was then shared online and reviewed for the purpose of collaborative meaning-making. Drawing heavily from Chang et al. (2013) on 'meaning-making' which according to him 'is like holding chunks of data against a backdrop and understanding what the data mean in relation to other segmented data within the broader context' (p. 116). Fig. 2 depicts the trajectory of Researcher A's reflective process.

As indicated in STEP 2 of Fig. 2, after discussions with Researcher B, Researcher A realised that she was 'able to understand the descriptive comments at a more metacognitive' and conceptual level, by providing meaning to it, such as for example, in the case of 'silence'. On the one hand, as discussed by Researcher A in STEP 3, if interviews are regarded as information gathering tools, then, obviously, researchers need to ask the participants to recollect as much information as possible. On the other hand, if interviews are regarded as a dialogic activity between the researcher and the participant, and if the interview process is to be used as a tool for 'knowledge construction', then, researchers can be more flexible in terms of their understanding towards moments of silence in interviews. However, as shown in STEP 3, such an understanding could lead to more questions such as those regarding the power relationship between the researcher and the participant and how the identities of each party shape the interviews.

4. Results and discussion

In pursuance of the research question to explore how CAE functions as a tool for professional development, the collected data were analyzed, which yielded results pertaining to: 1) the professional developments observed, 2) the paths of developments the individual researchers undertook, and 3) how collaborative dialogues promoted the researchers' reflexivity. The results provided evidence to support that CAE can be a highly effective tool in promoting professional development because it creates abundant opportunities for collaborative dialogues in which a 'collective exploration of researcher subjectivity' takes place (Chang et al., 2013, p. 25). Further, such dialogues encourage 'deeper learning about self and other' (ibid.) through individual and collaborative reflection.

4.1. Researchers' developments

The study yielded a total of eight sets of pre and post-dialogue reflective writing by each researcher, in addition to the overall reflection of CAE. On comparing the entries, it was found that the post-dialogue entries were longer and more extensive and probing. A concern which Researcher B expressed in her personal reflection, prior to the joint reflection was that, she was unable to follow the same procedure with all interviewees and was concerned if she was conducting the interviews in the 'right' way. This concern was shared by the researcher during the face-to-face dialogue with Researcher A, when she shared her experience of conducting interview

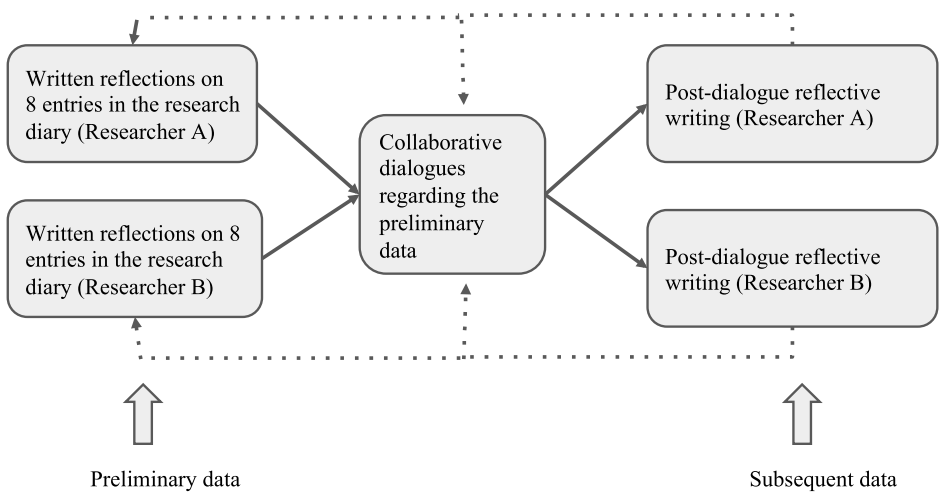


Fig. 1. Data collection process.

STEP 1: Pre-dialogue reflective writing (May, 2018)	STEP 2: Post-dialogue reflective writing (June, 2018)	STEP 3: Final reflective writing after reading each other's post-dialogue reflective writing (July, 2018)
Sample Extract: Relieved to know that the logistics and the practical part of the interview went well but there are concerns such as 'silence'. Would I be asking leading questions if I intervened? How should I build rapport?	Sample Extract: Relieved that my research partner was also having similar issues. But why are we concerned about the moments of 'silence' so much? Are 'good' interviews equivalent to getting information? Shouldn't interviews be regarded as a process of 'knowledge' construction?	Sample Extract: In pre-writing, my comments are descriptive. After discussion with my partner, I was able to understand the descriptive comments at a more metacognitive level, and began to think of interviews in a different light; that is, to regard 'interviews' as 'construction of knowledge'. ……but then, for instance, how about the relationship between the researcher and the participant, and the power relationship?

Fig. 2. An example or pre- and post-reflective journal by Researcher A.

research, and when both the researchers shared information pertaining to the interview-related resources which were consulted during the learner autonomy research. The post-dialogue entry by Researcher B is enumerated as follows:

> Thanks to our dialogue, I have realised that there were many more things that researchers need to pay attention to: maintaining the motivation of interviewees regarding research participation (especially when asking for long-term commitment), having awareness of the possibility of changes in the relationship with the research participants, checking whether the interview is in fact co-construction, being cognisant of the difference between the analysis done while listening to the interviewee and the analysis at the data analysis stage. (excerpt from reflective writing after the 3rd collaborative dialogue)

Moreover, she made a list of questions that she felt should be explored further, such as 'What does "in-depth" refer to in in-depth interviews?', 'Are semi-structured interviews really empowering for the participants?', and 'What is the difference between co-construction and bias?', along with the relevant information from the literature. In other words, while the pre-dialogue entry were purely a description of the personal reflection of the researcher's own experience, the post-dialogue entry was a richer record of researcher reflexivity, which consisted of renewed inferences as well as new perspectives and questions inspired by the dialogue with the partner researcher, which could promote future development of an individual as a researcher.

Researcher A	Researcher B
Attained a better understanding of what it means when we say interviews are a discursive accomplishment. Reinforced the understanding of bias, the leading questions (and the delicate line between the two). Re-acknowledged the significance of the researcher's identities in the research process. Re-acknowledged the significance of reflexivity.	Increased understanding on what makes a successful interview with respect to the researcher–participant relationship. Better realisation of the significance of research experience. Enhanced understanding of research participants' perspectives and feelings. Acknowledged researchers' bias and stereotypes and their importance in research. Extensive examination of theories related to interviews.

Fig. 3. Perceived changes noted in the researchers' overall reflection of CAE.

Another example that illustrates the researcher's continued development is shown in Fig. 2. Researcher A was well aware of the shift in the interview literature (i.e. interview-*as*-technique to interview-*as*-local-accomplishment) (Kvale, 1994), but she was not aware of this at the time of the learner autonomy research, and the extent of reverberations it can have on a researcher's identity, how it could shape the entire interview process, and how issues such as researcher disclosure and factors such as bias come into play in the conversations. This personal reflection took a different turn in the dialogues with Researcher B which led to a deeper understanding of the meaning of theorising interviews as a discursive and locally situated act (refer to the 1st column in Fig. 3). Similarly, through engagement in CAE Researcher B become aware that she did not give much thought to her own bias during the learner autonomy research, because she was not actually teaching the research participants. She realised why Researcher A was concerned about bias. Consequently, she began to realise the possibility of a potential bias which she might have had during her original research, and acknowledged the importance of researchers' bias and perceived ideas and their influence in research. These examples support the benefits of CAE reported in previous studies on similar topics and CAE literature. 'Deeper learning about self and others' (Chang et al., 2013, p.25) may be particularly significant, reflecting the ongoing self-awareness through collaborative dialogues.

Finally, one notable outcome and possibly the biggest benefit of CAE was the in-depth and wide range of areas of professional developments for both researchers. Fig. 3 is a summary of the self-perceived changes which we wrote after the final dialogue reflecting on comparing what we noted in the original research diaries five years ago with what we thought after going through the process of CAE.

4.2. *Different paths of development for different researchers*

It is crucial to state that the researchers involved in the collaborative dialogues neither gained the same kind of understanding nor achieved a higher level of reflexivity in a similar manner, and to the same extent and degree. In fact, we took our own unique paths of development. One example is regarding the complexity of having a researcher–participant relationship as well as a teacher–student relationship in the learner autonomy research. This was a common concern because Researcher A experienced this dual relationship whereas Researcher B experienced researcher–participant relationship only. At the time of the learner autonomy research, Researcher A perceived this role overlap as a problem and felt that sometimes it led to unsuccessful interviews. This reflection made her focus on rapport building and the establishment of a supportive environment for the research participants because she thought that if her interviewees were more comfortable, they might reveal their inner most honest selves to the researcher. On the contrary, Researcher B found that the lack of the role overlap was advantageous as well as disadvantageous. As she was not involved in teaching the participants, she often realised that she was unable to contextualise the questions or the responses. At the same time, the fact that she had to rely on the participants for the required information, which helped both of them to engage in a conversation without worrying about the power relationship, would have been impossible in teacher–student relationship. The following is a part of the dialogue on the discussion of the researcher–participant relationship:

> Researcher A: *When the participants were 1st year students, they may have seen the benefits of talking to their teachers […] Once they became second year students with no more English classes to take, some of them may have seen no benefit of continuing the research. Such students dropped out of the research. […] This makes me think some kind of reward is necessary to keep participants in research, especially longitudinal studies like ours.*
>
> Researcher B: *Since I wasn't teaching any of my interviewees, my relationship with them remained the same as that of a researcher-participant during the two years of our data collection. I wonder that's why neither participant dropped out.*
>
> Researcher A: *Many, well, most researchers stress the elimination of power relationship between the researcher and the participant exactly for that reason. But it is not always possible. Therefore, I think it is important to clearly state, when presenting the analysis, potential elements that may have influenced the interviewees.*
>
> Researcher B: *In our last conversation, we talked about 'how to do successful interviews' guidelines and lists of dos and don'ts. That seems relevant to what we are talking about here. I wonder if you become 'freer' from these general rules as you experience more research in your field […] you might be more sure of YOUR dos and don'ts in your specific research context … (excerpts from the 3rd collaborative dialogue)*

In the dialogue, some interesting differences between the two researchers became apparent. Researcher A realised that she believed that participants should take control of the interviews that partly came from her effort to transform the power relationship between the teacher and students into the researcher–participant relationship by allowing the participants to take the lead during the interview process. Researcher B often shared the interview topics in advance, assuming that her interviewees can prepare what to share with the researcher. In other words, Researcher B saw information sharing about the research as a way to empower the participants, who might otherwise be passive in offering the information the researcher wants. Answering the questions posed by Researcher A helped her to reflect on her belief that the researcher and participants should be partners of co-construction and therefore should not be forced to play 'expected' roles of a researcher or an interviewee. Both researchers gained a better understanding of themselves as researchers as they exposed to different perspectives brought by the partner researcher and had to explain their own practices on a particular aspect of research. The quote mentioned below has been extracted from Researcher A's post-dialogue reflective writing:

> *The comments I made after discussions with my research partner definitely was very productive: in the process of meaning-making of a certain phenomenon, action or behaviour. I was able to better understand the role that I played in the creation of 'knowledge'. I was able to self-monitor myself and the impact of my biases, beliefs and personal experiences on the self on the research. In other words, we must*

not simply report the facts or truths, but construct knowledge through one's experiences, and then question how those interpretations came about. This would not have been possible if the process was done individually on my own. The discussions with my research partner enabled me to see things from a different, multitude of perspectives in deeper and enriching ways. This, needless to say, has great implications and how we analyse and interpret data. What is important is to be aware of one's biases, assumptions and beliefs, and show how they influenced the construction of data, its analysis and interpretation. It was an enriching experience. (*excerpt from the 3rd post-dialogue reflection writing*)

This shows that sharing of the individual reflective experiences through writing allowed the researchers to view a particular idea or belief in a larger context of personal development, by indirectly experiencing the trajectory of the other person's development, documented in her reflective writing.

While the process of the self-perceived changes seems to prove the transformative power of CAE, the current study revealed implications with respect to CAE having a great potential in community building. Regardless of the differences in terms of previous knowledge and experiences pertaining to the topic, both of us gained new insights in various areas that contributed to our development as researchers. In other words, the two benefits of 'collaborative exploration of researcher subjectivity' and 'community building' (Chang et al., 2013) were strongly supported by our data.

4.3. Enhanced researcher reflexivity through meaning-making process of collaborative dialogues

As described above, engagement in CAE brought about various changes in both the researchers, which included increased awareness and reflexivity and better understanding of one's own practice and beliefs; they were also able to confirm the benefits of CAE. Therefore, it was worth analysing how the dialogues between the two of us instigated researcher reflexivity. The beneficial factors of CAE (Chang et al., 2013) are illustrated in Fig. 4.

Researchers need to reflect on and describe their own practice and beliefs about doing research at an individual level. However, the collaborative work was much more than merely digging into the past and exchanging thoughts. Instead, it turned out to be a meaning-making process in which we attempted to contemplate on the past incidences and realise their significance within a larger context of our professional lives. For example, researcher bias is a topic widely discussed in qualitative research. It is common to find ideas, in any textbook, that state that bias is something that a researcher must be aware of and should minimise. However, through extensive discussions on the topic involving our own experiences and our reflections on them, we were able to explore the following fundamental questions together: 'Is bias always bad?', 'Why do we consider something "biased"?', 'Where does bias coming from?' and 'How does bias influence the research process?'. Discussions on these questions served as a powerful resource that encouraged us to delve into our own thoughts and experiences.

It was also worth noting that personal reflective writing added another layer to the reflective process, and as we attended more sessions, we became more reflective. This meant that even while writing, we were acutely aware that our partner would read it and might ask questions, and the questions we may want to discuss. One could argue that our personal reflective writing became more of a collaborative dialogue on paper. Both of us often wrote in the journal, 'Can we talk about this point more when we meet?' This shows that we were engaged in personal reflection in anticipation of collaborative reflection. Such an outcome is one of the distinctive effects that emerge most prominently from collaborative dialogues. As Elbow (2009) eloquently puts it, 'Only from a new vantage point can we see our normal point of view from the outside and thereby notice assumptions that our customary point of view keeps hidden' (Elbow, 2009, pp. 5–6). Hence, it can be said that these collaborative dialogues lead to a more objective level of awareness concerning one's own experience, and to a conceptual level of understanding which may not be achieved through solo reflection (refer to Fig. 4).

The findings of the current study highlight some of the strengths of CAE as a tool for the professional development of qualitative researchers. It is through our collaborative interactions that we were able to reinforce or illuminate our present findings and view a particular phenomenon under study from an entirely different perspective. The collective interpretation of multiple perspectives enables each individual researcher to continue probing and examining the assumptions and beliefs that they hold, which is significant. The cyclical process provided us with more opportunities for increased reflexivity, and consequently better understanding of ourselves

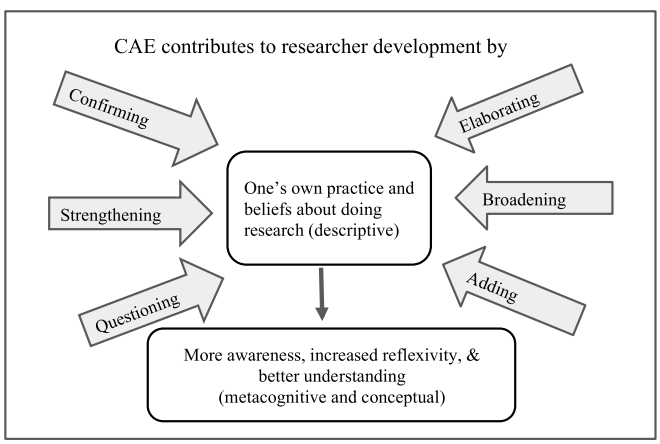


Fig. 4. Cognitive processes through which CAE contributes to researcher development.

and/or the phenomenon at hand.

5. Conclusion

Using researcher's reflexivity as the central tenet, this study lends support to CAE as a highly effective vehicle to promote researcher professional development as well as knowledge construction in research. Our dialogic accounts revealed how researchers are connected to the research context both on the micro level of the individual and the macro level of the society, and how these two dimensions intertwine to provide new meanings to the researchers' sense of self, experiences, and knowledge building. What was revealed through our dialogues that included a new understanding of the role and responsibility of the researcher, their positionalities and identities, and the researcher–participant relationship was a transformative experience. The research yielded insightful views on the process of collecting, analysing, and representing interview data.

Furthermore, the study provided additional support to the already documented benefits of CAE as a research methodology. Particularly, it illuminates distinctive advantages of 'collective exploration of researcher subjectivity' (Chang, 2013, p. 25) and 'deeper learning about self and other' (Chang, 2013, p. 82), as tools for professional development of researchers. Additionally, abundant resources are available regarding approaches, methodologies, and methods, but studying them individually brings forth certain concerns. For example, researchers may dismiss a significant element of a particular research approach simply because they do not understand it or it does not conform to their already held beliefs. Most researchers would admit that it can be extremely difficult to question, elaborate, widen, or even confirm their own practice and beliefs, and for this reason, their development as researchers may be slowed down or even compromised. Researchers who challenge their beliefs, ask for elaboration, and offer different ideas and experiences, encourage self-inquiry and can possibly shed light on the blind spots, which in turn leads to awareness of new issues as well as a better understanding of what they do and why they do it while being engaged in research. CAE helps researchers to re-orient themselves in a wider context of research while adding layers of understanding. Moreover, because constructive dialogue is central to CAE, both parties benefit, in different ways, by participating in it.

The study also highlighted some of the complexities involved in engaging with CAE in terms of its practical application for professional development. Firstly, the most notable feature was the benefit of including multiple voices; because of its multidimensional nature, the research team might ultimately end up spending considerable time in reaching an understanding. Secondly, a power imbalance between researchers could also exist; generally, the more experienced researcher attempts to dominate in almost all aspects of the entire research process. Thus, it is important that researchers involved in a collaborative research design show their willingness to learn from others. Furthermore, as we have observed, the nature of CAE requires much time and dedication from the researchers. This particular research was conducted when both the researchers were availing their research leave, which implied that the researchers themselves were more flexible in terms of the time they could devote on the study. Additionally, for considering CAE as ethically appropriate, certain ethical principles should be taken into account, such as: participation in the research should be conducted on a completely voluntary basis; and the content should be equally shared amongst all researchers involved in the study (Lapadat, 2017; De Costa et al., 2020). Finally, it should be highlighted that not all topics are suitable for CAE. Usually, topics are most likely to be limited to those that are of interest to the researchers involved.

Finally, we would like to turn our attention towards the process of writing the research report, the end product of every study. Autoethnography can come in a variety of forms ranging from the conventional research reports to the less conforming style that includes poetry, songs, films, and performance pieces (Jones et al., 2013). We opted to engage in a more typical academic discourse, and summarised the study in the style of an analytical-interpretive written report based on our understanding, to make it more accessible to prospective readers.

Author statement

There is no potential competing interest between the authors with the submission. The authors received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

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